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SECURITY



Google says UK government has not demanded an encryption backdoor for its users' data

The U.K. government is [reportedly backing down](#) from its earlier demand that Apple build a secret backdoor allowing its authorities access to customer data worldwide, following a harsh rebuke from the U.S. government. But one U.S. senator wants to know if other tech giants, like Google, have also received secret backdoor demands from the U.K. government.

Google refused to answer the lawmaker's questions but has since told TechCrunch that the technology giant has not received a backdoor demand, marking the first time that Google has confirmed it is not subject to a similar U.K. order.

IMAGE CREDITS: VINCENT ISORE / GETTY IMAGES

Earlier this year, The Washington Post reported that the U.K. Home Office [sought a secret court order in the U.K.'s surveillance court](#) demanding that Apple allow U.K. authorities to access the end-to-end encrypted cloud data stored on any customer in the world, including their iPhone and iPad backups. Apple encrypts the data in such a way that only customers, and not Apple, can access their data stored on its servers.

Under U.K. law, tech companies subject to secret surveillance court orders, such as Apple, are legally barred from revealing details of an order, or the existence of the order itself, despite [details of the demand publicly leaking earlier this year](#). Critics called the secret order against Apple “draconian,” saying it would have [global](#)

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[ramifications for users' privacy](#). Apple has [since appealed the legality of the order](#).

In [a new letter](#) sent to top U.S. intelligence official Tulsi Gabbard on Tuesday, Sen. Ron Wyden, who serves on the Senate Intelligence Committee, said that while tech companies cannot say whether they have received a U.K. order, at least one technology giant has confirmed that it hasn't received one.

Meta, which uses end-to-end encryption to protect user messages sent between WhatsApp and Facebook Messenger, told Wyden's office on March 17 that the company has "not received an order to backdoor our encrypted services, like that reported about Apple."

Google, for its part, would not tell Wyden's office if it had received a U.K. government order for accessing encrypted data, such as Android backups, "only stating that if it had received a technical capabilities notice, it would be prohibited from disclosing that fact," said Wyden.

Google spokesperson Karl Ryan told TechCrunch in a statement: "We have never built any mechanism or 'backdoor' to circumvent end-to-end encryption in our products. If we say a product is end-to-end encrypted, it is."

When explicitly asked by TechCrunch, Ryan said: "We haven't received a technical capabilities notice," referring to any U.K. surveillance order.

Wyden's letter, first reported by [The Washington Post](#) and [shared with TechCrunch](#), called on Gabbard to make public its "assessment of the national security risks posed by the U.K.'s surveillance laws and its reported secret demands of U.S. companies."

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This story was updated with additional comment from Google, shared in response to a TechCrunch inquiry.

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UK's secret Apple iCloud backdoor order is a global emergency, say critics



In its latest [attempt](#) to erode the protections of strong encryption, the [U.K. government has reportedly secretly ordered Apple to build a backdoor](#) that would allow British security officials to access the encrypted cloud storage data of Apple customers anywhere in the world.

The secret order — issued under the U.K.'s Investigatory Powers Act 2016 (known as the Snoopers' Charter) — aims to undermine an opt-in Apple feature that provides [end-to-end encryption \(E2EE\)](#) for iCloud backups, called Advanced Data Protection. The encrypted backup feature allows only Apple customers to [access their device's](#) information stored on iCloud — not even Apple can access it.

While the U.K. government declined to comment to TechCrunch on the report, British officials have [long argued](#) that E2EE makes it more difficult to gather digital evidence for criminal prosecutions and collect intelligence for national security.

Apple's encrypted backup feature, once enabled, closes a loophole that law enforcement has [used to gain access to cloud-stored data](#). This data was otherwise impossible to unscramble on most modern iPhones that have device encryption enabled.

IMAGE CREDITS: [NATALIYA ROMASHOVA/EYEEM](#)
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The Washington Post, which [first reported the story](#), said Apple will likely stop offering the iCloud encryption feature to users in the United Kingdom in response to the secret order, rather than break the encryption of users globally.

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warned that [the U.K. government's draconian order would not make citizens safer](#) but would instead “erode the fundamental rights and civil liberties of the entire population.”

While it's not yet clear how the U.K. order works in practice — removing Advanced Data Protection would only make the cloud data of U.K. citizens available to law enforcement — news of the order sparked concerns that the security for millions of Apple device owners all over the world could be weakened.

Security and privacy advocates also say that the U.K. could set a dangerous global precedent that authoritarian regimes and cybercriminals will be eager to exploit — any backdoor developed for government use would inevitably be exploited by hackers and other governments.

Thorin Klosowski, a privacy activist at the U.S.-based Electronic Frontier Foundation, also warned

In a blog post that the U.K.'s demands [will have global ramifications](#) that make the secret order an “emergency for us all.” James Baker at the Open Rights Group said [last week](#) that the plans are “frightening ... and would make everyone less safe.”

A security lesson not learned

The knock-on effect that the U.K. government's order could have on citizens around the world has sparked criticisms amid fears that it could put the U.K. at odds with some of its closest allies.

The news comes just weeks after U.S. security authorities urged Americans [to use encrypted messaging apps](#) to avoid having their communications intercepted by adversarial nations. The advisory followed [reports of a years-long stealthy hacking campaign](#) by Chinese government spies aimed at hacking into critical U.S. infrastructure, as well as phone and internet giants.

The Computer & Communications Industry Association (CCIA), a U.S. tech industry group that represents the IT and telecoms industries, [said the hacks](#) carried out by the [“Typhoon” group of Chinese-backed hackers](#) makes it clear that “end-to-end encryption may be the only safeguard standing between Americans' sensitive personal and business data and foreign adversaries.”

“Decisions about Americans' privacy and security should be made in America, in an open and transparent fashion, not through secret orders from abroad requiring keys be left under doormats,” the CCIA said.

Chris Mohr, president of U.S.-based Software Information Industry Association, also [issued a](#)

[similar warning](#), calling the U.K. order “both ill-advised and dangerous.”

“Particularly in the wake of Salt Typhoon, we need policies to make information more (not less) secure,” said Mohr, referring to the China-backed group that targeted phone companies. “We call on the Trump Administration and the U.S. Congress to take a firm stand against this troubling development.”

The Chinese hacks that targeted phone and internet giants — [including AT&T and Verizon](#) — are the most recent examples of why the U.K. government’s backdoor demands on Apple are flawed.

Salt Typhoon carried out the telco breaches, said to be one of the biggest hacks in recent history, by [abusing a legally mandated backdoor required by telecom firms](#) to give law enforcement and intelligence agencies access to their customers’ data on request.

“The lesson will be repeated until it is learned: there is no backdoor that only lets in good guys and keeps out bad guys,” according [to the Electronic Frontier Foundation](#). “It’s time for all of us to recognize this, and take steps to ensure real security and privacy for all of us.”

Topics: [Apple](#) [cybersecurity](#) [encryption](#) [iCloud](#)

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Apple pulls iCloud end-to-end encryption feature for UK users after government demanded backdoor

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

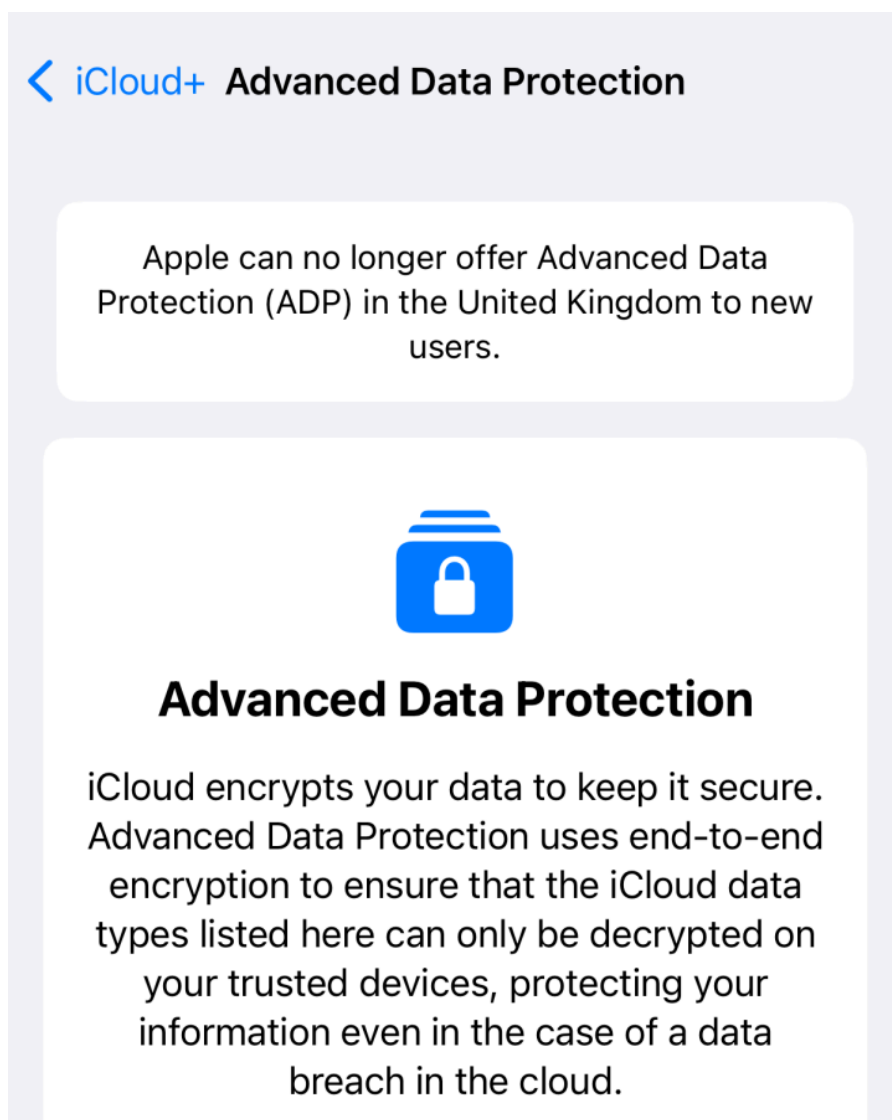
— 7:58 AM PST · February 21, 2025

Apple confirmed Friday that it “can no longer” offer a security feature that allows users in the United Kingdom to encrypt their iCloud data.

In a statement provided to TechCrunch, Apple spokesperson Fred Sainz said the company's [Advanced Data Protection](#) feature will no longer be available to new users and current U.K. users "will eventually need to disable this security feature."

"We are gravely disappointed that the protections provided by ADP will not be available to our customers in the U.K. given the continuing rise of data breaches and other threats to customer privacy," the company said.

"Enhancing the security of cloud storage with end-to-end encryption is more urgent than ever before," the statement said.



A SCREENSHOT OF THE MESSAGE APPLE SHOWS TO U.K. USERS AFTER DISABLING THE OPTION TO TURN ON END-TO-END ENCRYPTED ICLOUD.

IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

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The announcement comes after the [U.K. government reportedly ordered](#) Apple earlier this year to build a [backdoor](#) that would allow British authorities “blanket” access to users’ data stored on Apple’s cloud servers, even if it is [end-to-end encrypted](#). This request, seen as unprecedented in a modern democracy, [alarmed privacy and security experts](#), who argued that if the British government prevailed, the demand would set a precedent for authoritarian countries to follow.

Apple offers users the option to turn on end-to-end encrypted iCloud backups through Advanced Data Protection. This feature effectively makes it impossible for anyone, including Apple and government authorities, to view data stored in iCloud by users who have opted-in.

A spokesperson for the U.K. Home Office did not immediately respond to TechCrunch’s request for comment.

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Apple did not immediately say how the process of disabling ADP will work for users who had already turned it on before Friday.

James Baker, who works for the U.K. digital rights organization Open Rights Group, said that “The Home Office’s actions have deprived millions of Britons from accessing a security feature. As a result, British citizens will be at higher risk of their personal data and family photos falling into the hands of criminals and predators.”

Apple said that some types of data, including health data, messages stored in iCloud, and payment information, which are end-to-end encrypted by default for all users, will not be affected by this change, and will remain encrypted for everyone. But U.K. users will not be able to opt-in to use end-to-end encryption for the other types of data, such as photos, notes, backups, [and other data](#), which were encrypted under ADP.

For those who already have ADP enabled, Apple said it will give customers more guidance soon, as well as a period of time to disable the feature to keep using iCloud.

ADP is unaffected for users outside of the United Kingdom, Apple said, and end-to-end encrypted communication services like FaceTime and iMessage are not affected, either.

“As we have said many times before, we have never built a backdoor or master key to any of our products or services and we never will,” Apple said, linking to [its prior statements](#).

[BBC News reported](#) that ADP stopped being an option for new users starting at 3 p.m. U.K. time on Friday. TechCrunch has also confirmed that ADP is no longer an option for new users in the United Kingdom.

Since the rise of encryption in the mid-1990s, governments worldwide have argued that this data-scrambling technology would allow criminals and terrorists to break the law while evading law enforcement. Over the years, authorities have always found a way, from accessing unencrypted backups to using spyware, to access data directly on people’s devices.

“If you are not in the U.K., you should turn on ADP now,” Matthew Green, a cryptography expert and teacher at Johns Hopkins University, [wrote on X](#) in response to the news.

“The more people who use it, the harder it will be to shut off this way,” said Green.

Clarified the forms of data protected under Advanced Data Protection in the ninth paragraph.

This story was updated to include the statement from James Baker.

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